CHAPTER 26

LOLA

This time, I am around. It is a coincidence, a happy accident balanced against England's touring schedule, but one I am incredibly grateful for. The pregnancy has happened this time without too much alarm – a huge amount of fretting and worry, of course – but everything has happened smoothly. Daniella doesn't want to go to the hospital too soon. The events of last year have not lived well with either of us and she would rather not suffer the panic and the paranoia she had last time.

As the time comes closer and closer, I am panicking that our daughter is going to be born at home, and I'm going to be delivering her. Eventually I talk Daniella into going to the hospital. I drive her in on the evening of 7 January 2009, when she is 5cm dilated. It's too late for pain relief. She doesn't want gas and air and is in labour for eight hours. She's in absolute agony, screaming in the hospital. I'm in complete awe of her, the way she is dealing with it, but occasionally slightly also over-aware and self-conscious of how loud she is screaming. I may or may not, at one point in the barrage of agony, ask her, very gently, to 'sshhhhh'. As soon as I do it, I know I will regret it for the rest of my life. In time, it will be funny to Daniella, but it is not now. The labour is absolutely excruciating and I'm doing my best to be there for her, taking a mental note that the shushing is not the best approach, and constantly working out what I should and shouldn't be saying or doing. Compared to playing Test cricket for England, this is the absolute unknown, a total terror, where I'm completely at sea.

Daniella eventually gives birth to Lola at 4am on the morning of 8 January. When she holds her in her arms for the first time, she looks at her and says, 'I want another one.' I am astounded, given what she has just been through. But, despite being confused that she wants to go through it all